

▼ HANGUL

Until the mid-15th century, the Korean language was written using classical Chinese characters, but these were difficult to learn and only the educated knew them. In 1446, the Hangul script became the official Korean alphabet. It contained just 28 letters and was much easier to learn.



Each quarter of this wooden seal features a Hangul character.



◀ RAIN GAUGE

During the reign of Sejong the Great, the cheugugi rain gauge was invented and distributed all across the kingdom. This instrument helped people keep accurate records of rainfall, which helped them predict the weather and therefore improve crop harvests.

SHIN SAIMDANG ▶

Shin Saimdang was one of the most famous artists, writers, and calligraphers under the Joseon dynasty during the 16th century. She painted nature scenes, particularly flowers and insects. Two of her poems still survive, but most examples of her calligraphy have been lost over the years.



1450-1750

IMJIN WAR

Japan twice invaded the Joseon Kingdom in the 1590s, in a conflict known as the Imjin War. Early in the conflict, the Japanese laid siege to the fortress at Busan (below), killing 8,000 Koreans. The war ended when the Japanese withdrew in 1598.

